Four Agreements for Courageous Conversations

1. Stay engaged.

There may be times when your own or others' reactions might make you want to disengage from the conversation and process of exploring your and others' reactions. Participating in a courageous conversation asks participants to stay engaged, even when not sharing openly, to show you are listening, working to understand others' perspectives, and to explore your own.

2. Speak your truth.

Remember that regardless of whether you or others agree with one another, consider what you know to be true and speak it. When considering your worldview and comparing it with others, your worldview or others' may seem untrue or "impossible"; however if it is what someone is sharing, it must be true in their experience, just as what you are sharing is true in your experience. Speak your truth, others will learn simply by being exposed to an experience of another person, whether your truth is the same as theirs or different.

3. Experience discomfort.

Discomfort often is the result of conflicting reactions. Sitting with discomfort can produce incredible outcomes when it comes to controversial topics. There are theories that say that long periods of discomfort can sometimes lead us to move toward comfort due to the exposure. In addition, often when our reactions are different than others we want to find ways to make ourselves more comfortable which often leads us to withdraw from the conversation or attack others. This is a response to discomfort. In this process, do your very best to experience discomfort and let yourself feel that way without trying to solve it. It is not talking about these issues that create divisiveness. The divisiveness already exists in the society and in our schools. It is through dialogue, even when uncomfortable, the healing and change begin.

4. Expect and accept non-closure.

While it is your facilitator's goal to work toward greater understanding for the whole group, it is impossible with the time we have together to reach complete closure around every aspect of what we are talking about. For that reason, expect non-closure and be ready to accept it as a possible successful outcome of the courageous conversation process.

COURAGEOUS CONVERSATION COMPASS MODEL
A model to help us understand our reactions to controversial topics

*(**Reference/Adapted from:** Singleton, Glenn E. 2015. Courageous Conversations About Race: a Field Guide for Achieving Equity in Schools 2nd ed. Thousand Oaks, CA: Corwin.)

MORAL REACTIONS	**INTELLECTUAL REACTIONS**
Moral reactions are a person's beliefs about the topic being discussed. Beliefs can be evaluative (good, bad), values-based (how something should be done or whether it should be done), and existential/ (whether something exists or not). In this box folks may include their current or past beliefs and most importantly how beliefs are impacted by the film/speaker/ exposure to the topic.	Intellectual reactions are thoughts that individuals have about the topic being discussed. These are often large- scale observation or considerations and can connect to theory, broader concepts, etc. Our intellectual response is often verbal and based in our best thinking.
EMOTIONAL REACTIONS	**SOCIAL REACTIONS**
Emotional reactions are feelings that people have in response to an experience. Sometimes folks go from feeling straight to thinking. Feeling statements should start with "I feel..." followed by a feeling word. Often controversial or intense issues strike us at a physical level and cause an internal sensation such as embarrassment, sadness, shock, or resentment etc. ("I feel that..." or "I feel like..." are often followed by statements that do not describe how someone is feeling but what they are thinking)	Social reactions are about how the individual reacts or responds around the topic in a social environment. So, participants should consider what they might do when it comes to the topic if they were to encounter it in their typical social environment. Relationally: we connect and respond to information through our acting or what is most often characterised as specific behaviours and actions.

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MORAL REACTIONS	**INTELLECTUAL REACTIONS**
I believe…	I think…
EMOTIONAL REACTIONS	**SOCIAL REACTIONS**
I feel…	In a social setting I…

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